Poem: London

London

I wander through each chartered street

Near where the chartered Thames does flow,

And mark in every face I meet

Marks of weakness, marks of woe.

Chartered is something which is listed and regulated, the streets are clearly controlled but it suggests the Thames, the river likewise is controlled, nature controlled by man.

Blake is suggesting that everyone is without power and in misery, a powerful statement indeed. The term mark can be a ***metaphor*** *for a brand, as if these people don't like look tired, but are branded with this look to show their place in society.*

Repetition *of 'in every' used to show scale of suffering.*

In every cry of every Man,

In every Infants cry of fear,

In every voice: in every ban,

The mind-forged manacles I hear:

Alliteration *of mind/manacles helps draw our attention to the* ***metaphor****, Blake is showing that these people are not physically held back, but their belief in their own weakness holds them back.*

The ***juxtaposition*** *but also connection between the cries of children made to sweep chimneys and therefore from the rooftops, and church bells which ring out is striking. Blake saw religion as a tool to keep the people down and therefore was wrong* ***'blackening'****.*

This contrasts the cries of the innocent dirty children with the supposedly clean but corrupt church.

How the Chimney-sweepers cry

Every black'ning Church appalls,

And the hapless Soldiers sigh

Runs in blood down Palace walls .

This draws on the link to war at this time. The blood running down palace walls signifies their sacrifice to protect the power of those who live in the palaces. It is a ***symbolic metaphor****.*

Harlots is ***slang*** *for prostitutes or low class women. Blake is corrupting the idea of childbirth with sexual exploitation and hate 'curse'. The new born infant is born into a broken world.*

But most thro' midnight streets I hear

How the youthful Harlots curse

Blasts the new-born Infants tear,

And blights with plagues the Marriage hearse.

Oxymoron *which* ***juxtaposes*** *the joy of marriage with the misery of death. Blake is suggesting that society has destroyed all the good things in life.*

William Blake

Note how the poem uses **Quatrains** with **alternate rhyme** *abab* to create the **rhythm** of the narrator walking.

If you want to help your understanding you could:

-Look up more information about the conditions of life in Georgian/Victorian England.

-Read the poem aloud and consider the different tones in the poem.

Context:

William Blake was a poet in Victorian/Georgian England, he wrote a selection of poems in his anthologies songs of innocence and experience, most of those poems had a counterpart. The Experience poems were often more bitter or cynical whereas the innocence poems were often naïve and simple. London is one of the few without a counterpart.

The poem is set during a time in England where there was poverty, child labour and a horrific war with France. Women had no rights, death rates from disease and malnutrition were high and the industrial revolution has resulted in many large oppressive factories. Blake's poems often railed against these and how London, arguably the greatest city in the world at that time, was so dirty and corrupt.

Blake's anthology containing both sets of

Themes:

Looking at power and conflict this is a poem which is more about the lack of power and abuse of power. The poem is set in the capital of the most powerful country in the world and yet words like 'manacles' suggest slavery while the soldiers sigh 'runs in blood down palace walls' a clear contrast between those with power and those without.

Revolution and People Power:

During this time France had thrown off and executed their king. The People's revolution was meant to show that all men are equal and have power. In Britain, a country with an old monarchy and aristocracy, this was scary. Blake is perhaps supporting revolution, asking people to throw off the 'manacles' of their belief that they should be told what to do.

Structure: Written in four stanzas with an regular alternate scheme. This may reflect the regular walking pace of the narrator as he walks around London. The last line in each stanza tends to deliver a powerful statement which sums up the rest of the stanza. Stanza 1 focusses on misery, Stanza 2 on peoples refusal to stand tall, Stanza 3 about the way people are sacrificed for the rich and powerful, Stanza 4 how all this poverty is corrupting everything good about family and life.

By the end of this you should know:

Higher Marks	Lower Marks
-The poem is an ironic look at misery in the greatest city in the world. *-Blake's views are revolutionary for the time, challenging the idea that man is worth more than slavery.* *-Blake challenges the establishment in their 'palaces 'and 'churches' which are marked by the blood and blackening of good people.*	*-The poem is about the misery of life in London.* *-The poet is upset at the loss of joy and innocence.* *-People in power are living on the pain of others.*

Space for your notes: